PIA2050 Comparative Politics and Societies — Week 6 Summary: The Politics of Regime Transitions

1. Lecture Framing

Keywords: descriptive vs explanatory task, democratization, de-democratization, autocracies, democracies

- The lecture first finishes Week 5's regime-type slides (Slide 2). Week 5 was **descriptive** (surveying regime types); Week 6 is **explanatory** (Slide 13).
- Democratization — the process by which a regime becomes more democratic; de-democratization — the process by which a regime becomes less democratic.
- **Part I — Autocracies:** why non-democracies become unstable enough for democratization to happen (Slides 14–21).
- **Part II — Democracies:** (i) why democracy spread over 200 years; (ii) what makes democracies stable or unstable; (iii) why regime types vary by region (Slides 22–54).

2. Recap: Classifying Regimes

Keywords: Freedom House, political rights, civil liberties, Linz and Stepan, four regime types

2.1 Freedom House and the Variety of Non-Democracy (Slides 4–6)

Keywords: Free/Partly Free/Not Free, rights on paper, typology

- Freedom House ratings: countries are **Free / Partly Free / Not Free** on two dimensions, **political rights** and **civil liberties** (memorise).
- "Not Free" regimes differ in kind: personalised dictatorships, monarchies, military juntas, one-party regimes, theocracies (Slide 6).
- Many have constitutions that **guarantee rights on paper** → classify by practice, not by text.
- **EIU Democracy Index 2024 map** (Slide 3): global average 5.2/10; world population split **authoritarian 39.2% / flawed democracy 38.4% / hybrid 15.7% / full democracy 6.6%**.
- **Freedom in the World methodology** (Slide 5), a two-tier system of scores and status (memorise):
    - **0–4 points** per indicator: **10 political-rights** and **15 civil-liberties** indicators.
    - Political rights = Electoral Process (3), Political Pluralism and Participation (4), Functioning of Government (3) → **max 40**.

    - Civil liberties = Freedom of Expression and Belief (4), Associational and Organizational Rights (3), Rule of Law (4), Personal Autonomy and Individual Rights (4) → **max 60**.
    - A discretionary question on **forced demographic change** can subtract 1–4 points.
    - The previous year's scores are the benchmark; scores change only after a real-world development (e.g. a media crackdown, first free elections).
    - The combined PR + CL scores determine the status: **Free / Partly Free / Not Free**.

- **Autocracies at the end of 2021** (Slide 7, Siaroff 2022): **semi-liberal autocracies N = 48** (e.g. Hungary, Russia, Singapore, Turkey, Thailand) and **closed autocracies N = 41** (e.g. China, North Korea, Saudi Arabia, Vietnam, Venezuela).
- Linz & Stepan 1996 typology (memorise): authoritarian, totalitarian, post-totalitarian, sultanistic regimes.

2.2 Totalitarianism (Slide 8)

Keywords: total control, terror, monopoly of power, mass mobilisation, total ideology

- Totalitarianism — the state seeks to regulate every aspect of citizens' public and private life, including through extensive surveillance and terror.
- Giovanni Gentile: the state gives "total representation of the nation and total guidance of national goals." Benito Mussolini: "Everything within the state, nothing outside the state, nothing against the state."
- Features: **complete monopoly** of power; **forced or encouraged mass participation**; an **all-encompassing ideology** that legitimises and guides the regime.
- *Example:* communist (Stalin's USSR, Mao's China, Kim Il Sung's North Korea); nazi-fascist (Mussolini's Italy, Hitler's Germany).

2.3 Post-Totalitarianism (Slide 9)

Keywords: incomplete totalitarianism, PRC, de-ideologisation, decline of totalitarianism

- True totalitarian cases are **few** and **decades gone**; the USSR, PRC and fascist Italy were mostly incomplete totalitarianism.
- *Example:* the **PRC** became post-totalitarian once the party de-emphasised ideology, stopped mobilising the population, and relaxed economic control.
- Why totalitarianism declined (memorise):
    - (i) total control of a large territory and millions of people is hard, and **modernity** lets inconvenient information in;
    - (ii) total ideologies were **defeated in WW2 and the Cold War**.

2.4 Authoritarianism (Slide 10)

Keywords: limited pluralism, flexible ideology, performance legitimacy, passive obedience

- Power is **more constrained and dispersed**, sometimes allowing **limited pluralism**.

- Ideology matters less and is applied flexibly; legitimacy rests on **tradition/culture, national security, or economic performance**.
- The regime wants **passive obedience**, not active participation.
- Textbook subtypes: traditional, military (bureaucratic-military), religious, electoral authoritarianism.
- → Totalitarianism wants mobilised believers; authoritarianism settles for obedient subjects.

2.5 Sultanism (Slide 11)

Keywords: family plunder, personality cult, hereditary succession, personal loyalty

- Sultanism — power centred on one leader and his family, who amass wealth by plundering state coffers.
- No constraints on power; **personality cult**; all opposition banned; fear and surveillance; endemic corruption; **hereditary succession**; usually **no legitimacy**; officials' power comes from **personal ties** to the family.
- It can grow out of any regime type:
    - *Example:* communist: Kim Il Sung's North Korea, Ceaușescu's Romania.
    - *Example:* party-based: Saddam's Iraq, the Assads' Syria. Military-based: Gaddafi's Libya, Suharto's Indonesia.
    - *Example:* electoral democracy: Marcos's Philippines.

2.6 Eight Autocratic Subtypes (Slide 12)

Keywords: Siaroff, Linz and Stepan, traditional, military, theocratic, electoral authoritarianism, totalitarian variants, sultanism

- Slide 12 repeats Siaroff 2022's table (after Linz & Stepan 1996). Each subtype by its **source of legitimacy** and **route to democracy**:
    - **Traditional** (monarchy): tradition; the monarch must accept a figurehead role.
    - **Military:** the national interest; exits after losing legitimacy (e.g. a lost war) or "finishing the job".
    - **Theocratic:** authority to interpret scripture; has never democratized willingly.
    - **Electoral authoritarian:** the illusion of legal-rational authority; the key step is one truly free and fair election.
    - **Pre-/full/post-totalitarian:** ideology (plus charisma), shifting to performance in the post-totalitarian phase; full totalitarianism needs a post-totalitarian phase first, unless defeated and occupied.
    - **Sultanism:** fear, rewards, personal ties; must be overthrown, and insiders may hijack the transition.

3. Part I — Autocracies: Svolik's Politics of Authoritarian Rule

Keywords: Svolik 2012, authoritarian control, power-sharing, ruling coalition, co-optation, repression

3.1 Four Criteria and Two Conflicts (Slides 14–17)

Keywords: military involvement, party restrictions, legislative and executive selection, no enforcer, violence

- Svolik 2012 criticised the Week 5 typology and proposed four criteria (Slides 15–16, with data): **military involvement; restrictions on parties; legislative selection; executive selection**. → Measure regimes on several dimensions instead of one label.
- Authoritarian politics involves **two conflicts** (memorise):
    - **Ruler vs ruled** → the problem of authoritarian control (the excluded majority).
    - **Dictator vs allies** → the problem of authoritarian power-sharing: dictators need traditional elites, party members or generals to govern, and these allies can turn on them. **That is how most dictators fall.**
- Two defining features shape the solutions: (i) **no independent authority to enforce agreements**; (ii) **violence is the ultimate arbiter**.

3.2 Power-Sharing: Contested vs Established Autocracy (Slides 18–19)

Keywords: ruling coalition, personal autocracy, institutions, credible threat

- The dictator needs a ruling coalition — a group strong enough to guarantee the regime's survival.
- Coalitions fail when the autocrat grabs power from his allies; the **only deterrent is their threat to remove him**. The worst failure is a personal autocracy.
- Contested autocracy — dictator and allies balance each other; allies check him through a credible threat of rebellion.
- Established autocracy — the dictator monopolises power and usually loses it only through death, invasion or revolution.
- **The solution (Slide 19):** institutions that **reduce secrecy among elites**, i.e. decision-making bodies in **ruling parties or legislatures**:
    - formal rules for membership, promotion and decisions → information flows and compliance is easy to check;
    - transparent, regular interaction → allies are reassured the dictator will keep sharing power.
- **Caveat:** these work **only if allies keep a credible threat of force**. → Authoritarian parties are commitment devices, not window-dressing.

3.3 Control: Co-optation and Repression (Slides 20–21)

Keywords: regime party, patronage, career stakes, moral hazard, military leverage

- Control uses **co-optation** and **repression**; both have pros and cons.
- **Co-optation via parties:** they distribute services and benefits hierarchically, control appointments, recruit and repress selectively, and exploit **career ambitions**, so the most capable citizens get a **stake in the regime's survival**.
    - Cruder ways of buying loyalty that divert resources are often **unsustainable** (Week 12).
- **Repression is double-edged:** it can antagonise the population and creates a **moral hazard**: empowering repressive agents also increases their capacity to challenge the dictator and extract concessions beyond what is needed to suppress opposition.
- Dilemma: weaken the military, but you **need it** against threats from below.
- Military influence rises with (memorise): **concentrated wealth**, **state control of natural resources**, **ethnic/sectarian exclusion**.
- One-liner: *the more an autocracy relies on repression, the more power it hands to those holding the guns.*

4. Part II — Transition and Consolidation

Keywords: democratic transition, democratic consolidation, only game in town, Linz and Stepan

- Slide 23 (Svolik 2012) charts dictatorships **1946–2000**: their **number** rose from about 40 to a peak of about 115 in the late 1970s (with a jump around 1960, during decolonization), then fell to about 75 by 2000, with the sharpest drop in the early 1990s. Their **share of all countries** peaked at about 75% in the early 1970s and fell to about 40% by 2000. → The backdrop for Part II: democracy spread.
- Two phases (Slide 24):
    - Democratic transition — the process by which a non-democratic regime becomes democratic.
    - Democratic consolidation — the process by which a democratic regime achieves some permanence and stability.
- Linz & Stepan 1996: a consolidated democracy is **"the only game in town"** (memorise): all major political forces pursue their interests through the democratic process and cannot even envision backing another regime or using force to seize power.
- → Elections alone are not enough; the losers must accept defeat.

5. Huntington's Waves and Transition Types

Keywords: Huntington 1991, The Third Wave, reverse waves, transformation, replacement, transplacement

5.1 Three Waves, Three Reversals (Slides 25–31)

Keywords: wave dates, reverse waves, democratic stagnation, maps

- Huntington 1991: three waves of democratization, each followed by a reverse wave (memorise dates):
    - **1st wave 1828–1926:** rise of Western democracies → **1st reverse 1922–1942:** especially Fascism.
    - **2nd wave 1942–1962:** end of WWII, decolonization → **2nd reverse 1958–1973:** dictatorships in Asia, Africa, Latin America.
    - **3rd wave 1973–1991 (possibly 1999):** various causes → **3rd reverse?** since 2000, electoral and full democracies have stagnated or declined.
- Maps (Slides 26–31). Note the slide map labels the 1st wave **1828–1920** and the 3rd wave **1973–1999**.
    - 1st wave: North America, Western/Northern Europe, Australia/NZ, Chile, Argentina, Colombia, Japan.
    - 1st reverse: continental Europe falls to dictatorship; survivors are mainly the US, Canada, Britain, Ireland, Sweden, Finland, Chile and Australia/NZ.
    - 2nd wave: adds West Germany, Italy, Japan, India, Turkey, Indonesia, most of South America and some new post-colonial states (e.g. Nigeria, Botswana).
    - 2nd reverse: Latin America and new post-colonial states slide back.
    - 3rd wave: Southern Europe, Latin America, East Asia, post-communist Europe, much of Africa.
    - 3rd reverse? (2000–): the Freedom in the World 2026 map shows "Not Free" across much of Asia, the Middle East and Africa.
- → Progress is not linear; the waves overlap with their reversals.

5.2 Three Types of Transition (Slide 32)

Keywords: regime-led, opposition-led, negotiated, path dependence

- Transformation — a transition initiated and guided by the authoritarian regime in power.
- Replacement — an opposition causes the collapse or overthrow of the autocracy.
- Transplacement — a transition through deals and compromises between the old regime and democratic forces.
- The path depends partly on the **type of autocracy** being removed. Linking to Part I, regimes with institutionalised parties can steer or bargain, while personalist regimes are more likely to collapse.
- Memory hook: trans-FORM = regime leads; RE-place = opposition topples; trans-PLACE = both negotiate.

5.3 Transition Processes by Regime Type: Table 10.3 (Slide 33)

Keywords: Huntington, dictated, negotiated, abdicated, imposed, regime type

- Adapted from Huntington 1991 Table 3.1. Four **processes** crossed with the type of non-democratic regime (memorise one case per row):
    - **Dictated** (regime-led ≈ transformation): electoral authoritarian — **Mexico, Taiwan**; military — **Brazil, Chile, (Spain), Turkey**; post-totalitarian — **Bulgaria, Hungary**.
    - **Negotiated** (≈ transplacement): racial oligarchy — **South Africa**; military — **South Korea, Uruguay**; post-totalitarian — **Mongolia, Poland**.
    - **Abdicated** (≈ replacement/collapse): electoral authoritarian — **Tunisia**; military — **Argentina, Greece, Portugal**; full totalitarian — **Czechoslovakia, East Germany**; sultanistic — **Philippines (Marcos), Romania (Ceaușescu)**.
    - **Imposed by outside powers:** electoral authoritarian — **Grenada**; military — **Japan, Panama**; full totalitarian — **Nazi Germany**; sultanistic — **Iraq**.
- Note: European traditional authoritarian regimes tended to evolve into competitive oligarchies.
- → Pattern: totalitarian and sultanistic regimes **collapse or are conquered**; military and post-totalitarian regimes can **dictate or negotiate** their exit.

6. Why Consolidation Fails: Three Challenges (Slide 34)

Keywords: deepening, thick rule of law, regime performance, legitimacy, institutionalization

- Not every successful transition consolidates. The textbook names three challenges:
    - **Deepening:** make democracy more comprehensive, accountable and fair, moving from electoral to full democracy, so the public supports it and leaders reliably play by its rules; this requires a thick rule of law that **meaningfully constrains power**.
    - **Performance:** good policy outcomes → **legitimacy** → elites cooperate and the public complies → better performance (a virtuous circle).
    - **Institutionalization:** institutions and organizations acquire value and stability, becoming more resilient, efficient, predictable and adaptable.
- → Attitudes (deepening), outputs (performance), structures (institutionalization).

7. Three Big Questions (Slide 35)

Keywords: spread, stability, Western concentration, multi-causal

- 1: What explains democracy's spread over 200 years? 2: Why does it survive in some places and collapse in others? 3: Why did it start in the West, and why are the most successful democracies Western?
- None has a simple answer, and **different factors matter in different countries**.

8. Question 1 — Why Democracy Spread

Keywords: appeal, means vs end, recognition, capitalism, Industrial Revolution, new classes

8.1 The Appeal of Democracy (Slides 36–37)

Keywords: excluded groups, civil rights, political rights, redistribution, recognition

- Two parts to explain: why democracy appeals strongly enough that people **fight and die for it**, and why it spread **in the last 200 years** (Slide 36).
- Democracy appeals to **excluded or subordinate groups** (memorise):
    - **As a means to an end:**
        - **civil rights** protect against **arbitrary government**, so people can pursue their interests as equals whatever their birth or status;
        - **political rights** let the majority push for **redistribution**, freedom from exploitation, wider access to services, and a **minimum living standard**.
    - **As an end in itself:** it satisfies the desire for recognition, the desire to live in a society that recognizes one's equal worth, status and dignity.

8.2 Why Now: Capitalism and Social Transformation (Slides 38–39)

Keywords: industrial workers, bourgeoisie, urban middle class, alliances

- Democracy spread as **free-market capitalism** and the **Industrial Revolution** brought unprecedented growth, which transformed society (Slide 38):
    - **Peasants → industrial workers:** less traditional, easier to mobilise, organising for wages, conditions, services, redistribution and **voting rights**.
    - **Commercial/industrial bourgeoisie:** wanted political power to **match its economic strength** (Slide 39).
    - **Educated urban middle class:** wanted individual rights, **property protection**, upward mobility and **meritocratic** reform.
- Outcomes depend on each group's **size and strength**, its **organisation** into parties and movements, and the **alliances and rivalries** among groups.
- → Economic change → new classes → new demands and organising capacity → democratization.

9. Question 2 — Why Some Democracies Collapse (Slides 40–41)

Keywords: low development, economic crisis, elite fear of redistribution, middle-class co-optation, income threshold

- Key point: democracy is **vulnerable at low levels of development**, which exposes it to three threats (memorise):

    - **Economic crises** convince even the poorest that democracy cannot meet their basic needs.
    - **Wealthy elites**, including capitalists who once demanded opening, come to **fear redistribution**; this fear is strongest when the country is poor, so they become willing to overthrow democracy.
    - **A minority middle class** gives only **tenuous** support and can be **co-opted** by elites into anti-democratic projects.

- Above certain **high income levels** democracy is almost **"impregnable"**: if it survives the transition to developed status, or starts at high development, collapse risk is **virtually nil**.
- Context: this matches the standard finding of Przeworski & Limongi 1997 that development **sustains** democracies more than it creates them.
- One-liner: *poverty does not block transitions, but it makes breakdowns likely; wealth works like insurance.*
- **Oscillating states (Slides 42–43):** Siaroff 2022 lists **highly oscillating states since 1974** with repeated transitions and breakdowns:

    - *Example:* **Macedonia** — 4 transitions + 3 breakdowns = **7 regime changes** (autocracy 1973 → democracy 2021).
    - *Example:* 6 changes each — Albania, Bangladesh, Georgia, Niger, Sri Lanka, **Thailand**, Turkey.
    - *Example:* 5 each — Guinea-Bissau, Nigeria, Pakistan, Suriname, Ukraine, Zambia.
    - *Example:* 4 each — Haiti, Jamaica, Mali, Papua New Guinea, Philippines, Senegal.
    - **Thailand's Freedom House ratings 1972–2022** (Slide 43; scale 1 = best, 7 = worst): loops between **Not Free** (1972, 1976–77, 1991, 2006–07, 2014–21) and **Free** (1975, 1989–90, 1998–2004), with Partly Free spells in between → coups repeatedly reverse democratization.
    - → These are mostly lower- or middle-income cases, which fits the development argument above.

10. Question 3 — Why Is Successful Democracy Western?

Keywords: cultural explanations, Clash of Civilisations, Asian Values, critique, development explanation

10.1 Cultural Explanations (Slide 44)

Keywords: Huntington 1996, Lee Kuan Yew, value judgments

- Cultural explanations ask what in "Western" culture suits democracy, and they remain **popular**.
- *Example:* Western version: Huntington 1996, *The Clash of Civilisations*. Asian version: Lee Kuan Yew's Asian Values thesis. They differ in how they judge the "Asian" style of governance.

- Asian values has been **exposed as deeply flawed** (and "kind of racist").

10.2 Tommy Koh's Ten Asian Values (Slides 45–50)

Keywords: Koh 1993, communitarianism, family, education, social contract, responsible press

- Tommy Koh 1993, *International Herald Tribune*, "The 10 Values That Undergird East Asian Strength and Success." The lecturer asks whether **all** East Asians share them.

1. No extreme individualism: individuals balance their interests with family and society (Slide 45).
2. Strong families: low divorce, aged parents cared for (Slide 46).
3. Education revered by all strata; better maths and science scores (Slide 46).
4. Saving and frugality: *Example:* Singapore's saving rate vs a Western "addiction to consumption" (Slide 46).
5. Hard work, said to be why Asia is outcompeting Europe (Slide 47).
6. National teamwork: unions and employers as partners (Slide 47).
7. A social contract: the state provides order, jobs, housing, education and health; citizens obey, respect authority, work and save; no unemployment or single-mother welfare, to avoid the "Western disease of welfarism" (Slides 47–48).
8. Citizens as stakeholders: *Example:* over 90% of Singaporeans own homes; 50.5% own shares (vs UK 16.2%, US 11.7%); public-sector bonuses of 3.5 months' salary (Slides 48–49).
9. A morally wholesome environment: *Example: Playboy* unwanted; Seoul banned Michael Jackson; obscenity and attacks on religion not protected speech (Slide 49).
10. A free but "responsible" press with no absolute right; it must not stir up group or interstate conflict, and must grant a right of reply (Slide 50).

- Koh claims these values produced prosperity, harmony and order (*Example:* Singapore and Tokyo as the safest cities).
- → Many of the "values" are really **policy choices** (welfare design, censorship) presented as culture.

10.3 Critiques of the Cultural Argument (Slides 51–53)

Keywords: evidence, power interests, pro-democracy protests, Western past, regime-enforced culture

- **Evidence:** the claim needs proof that anti-democratic values (collectivism, deference to hierarchy and authority, intolerance) are **both widespread across Asia and unique to it**.
- **Interests:** views on culture track **power**; those in power and those who benefit from them hold one view, the powerless another.
- **Protests:** when Asians take to the streets it is usually **for democracy**, not dictatorship (Thailand an exception). Were they "duped by the West"?

- **The West's record (Slide 52):** Western countries have long authoritarian and hierarchical traditions and have mostly been democratic for **under a century**. Greek direct democracy (2,500 years ago) stayed local, and Asia has long local traditions of **elected leaders and public deliberation**. Eastern texts and practices also value freedom, equality, tolerance and debate.
- **Enforcement (Slide 53):** regimes spend heavily on propaganda, surveillance, censorship and on slandering, jailing or killing dissenters, so calling them a mere **reflection of culture** is "pretty absurd".
- Culture is **no obstacle**: democracy everywhere **continues some old values and breaks with others**. The desire for freedom and **equal recognition** is a **human** aspiration, neither Western nor Eastern.

10.4 The Better Explanation: Timing plus Development (Slide 54)

Keywords: early transformation, high development, strong authoritarian states, state–civil society mismatch

- The answer combines Questions 1 and 2 (memorise):
    - Democratization **started in the West** because the West underwent the democracy-favouring social transformations **first**.
    - Stable democracy **clusters in the West** because the West is **highly developed**; lower development elsewhere makes democracy unstable.
- Much of the non-West is **still undergoing** Europe's transformations of a century ago, often under **strong authoritarian regimes** that suppress or absorb challenges better than Europe's old aristocracies, thanks to **greater coercive power** and a **mismatch between strong states and weak civil societies**.
- One-liner: *the West's democratic lead comes from history and economics, not culture.*

11. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: recap, regime types, Svolik, Huntington, development, culture critique

11. **Framing (Slide 13):** Week 6 explains democratization and de-democratization. Part I covers autocracies; Part II covers democracies.
12. **Freedom House:** Free / Partly Free / Not Free, rated on political rights and civil liberties. "Not Free" regimes take many forms, with rights often only on paper.
13. **Linz & Stepan 1996:** totalitarian (total control and ideology, mass mobilisation) → post-totalitarian (the PRC) → authoritarian (limited pluralism, passive obedience; traditional/military/religious/electoral) → sultanistic (family plunder, personality cult, hereditary rule).
14. **Totalitarianism declined** because total control is infeasible in modern societies and total ideologies lost WW2 and the Cold War.

15. **Svolik 2012:** four criteria (military, parties, legislative and executive selection). Two conflicts: **control** (ruler vs ruled) and **power-sharing** (dictator vs allies; most dictators fall to their allies). There is no enforcer and violence decides.
16. **Contested vs established autocracy**; the worst case is personal autocracy. Parties and legislatures make elite deals transparent, but only if allies keep a **credible threat of force**.
17. **Control:** co-optation through parties and career stakes vs repression, which carries a **moral hazard**. The military gains leverage where wealth is concentrated, the state controls natural resources, or minorities are excluded.
18. **Transition vs consolidation:** a consolidated democracy is "the only game in town".
19. **Huntington 1991 waves:** 1828–1926 / reverse 1922–42; 1942–62 / reverse 1958–73; 1973–91(99) / reverse since 2000?
20. **Transition types:** transformation (regime-led), replacement (opposition topples), transplacement (negotiated). The type of autocracy shapes the path.
21. **Consolidation challenges:** deepening (thick rule of law), performance (the legitimacy circle), institutionalization.
22. **Q1 Spread:** democracy is valued as a means (rights, redistribution) and as an end (recognition). Capitalism and industrialisation created workers, a bourgeoisie and a middle class, and their strength, organisation and alliances shaped outcomes.
23. **Q2 Stability:** poor democracies face crises, elites who fear redistribution, and middle classes open to co-optation. Rich democracies are almost impregnable.
24. **Q3 Culture critique:** Huntington 1996, Lee Kuan Yew and Tommy Koh 1993 lack evidence that the values are both pan-Asian and unique; their views serve the powerful; Asians protest *for* democracy; the West was authoritarian until recently; regimes must enforce their "culture".
25. **Answer:** the West transformed first and is rich today. The non-West is still transforming, often under stronger coercive states. Freedom and recognition are human aspirations.